# HCP 1286 (cpc_1914-01-10_HU__HU_Jasz Arokszalas_jolanka-47): Feri to Jolánka Tóth, a partly read love letter

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**Status: PARTIAL. The cipher and key are established and most of the card reads as Hungarian, but one clause (rows 7 to 8) has no established sense and one word (**külvesben**, row 16) is not understood. Independent review 1 verdict REVISE, all findings addressed. No entry for the AI Decipherment Register is made.** Report dated 2026-11-02.

## Origin and context

The cryptogram is record 1286 of the HC Portal (https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1286), part of Tobias Schrödel's collection of cryptographic postcards. When captured on 2026-10-30 the portal listed it as **Not solved**, with no transcription or solution attached, category Substitution, date 1914-01-10, language Unknown (it is Hungarian), recipient Tóth Jolánka.

The address side is in plain handwriting: **Szépreményű Tóth Jolánka úrleánynak, Jászárokszállás** ("To the promising young lady Jolánka Tóth, Jászárokszállás"). A stamp, since torn away, was cancelled BUDAPEST 62 on 10 January 1914. The cipher fills the left half of the side in violet pencil, runs along the bottom edge, and continues in nine short rows on the paper under the torn stamp. Two postmarks and the machine cancel lines lie over part of the text. The picture side has printed verse and a photograph and no cipher.

The card belongs to the family of cipher postcards from a man signing Feri to Jolánka Tóth, of which HCP 1212, 1213, 1216, 1217, 1218, 1243 and 1301 are finished in this repository.



Address side: cipher at the left and under the torn stamp, plain address at the right (source/address-large.jpg)

## Method

The transcription is manual, made sign by sign by Claude Opus 5.5 from enlarged, saturation-boosted crops of the un-converted original scan, because violet pencil separates well from black postmark ink that way. No earlier GPT work exists on this card, and no published solution was found. A first attempt on 2026-10-30 stopped as partial; a second on 2026-11-02 re-read every row and went to review. The key was transferred unchanged from HCP 1216, and each sign of this card was then read against it.

## Key

Simple monoalphabetic substitution with invented graphic signs, the Jolánka family key:

| sign | letter | sign | letter | sign | letter |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| two bars | a | section mark | k | F-like | r |
| six | b | wave | l | right bowl | s |
| left bowl | c | three short strokes | m | gamma/corner | t |
| long stroke + short tick (joined) | d | two short strokes | n | plain cross x | u |
| three bars | e | cursive loop | o | chevron | v |
| upright cross + | f | tall stroke + short (h/p) | h / p | low descender | y |
| open loop with descender | g | dotted crossed curve | i | crossed diagonal | z |
| inverted T | j | joined loop + descender | gy | opposed bowls | cs |

Dots over o and u give ö and ü; other accents are mostly invisible and are supplied. The h/p sign is one near-homograph, separated by word sense. Plain ? and the numerals 1 and 2 are written as such.

## Plaintext

Marks used: [x] is supplied or hidden, {x} is read but not understood.

**Hungarian (normalized)**

Szeretett édes Jolánkám! Kívánom, hogy a legjobb egészségben találja soraim. Ami engem illet, csak megvagyok. E héten voltam a Sándornál, és ezt hallottam róla, hogy {bajosa|zeszebbolvalami}, hogy még ők, édesem, feljön[n]ek Pestre; hát így kezdtem örülni: közeljövőben gyakrabban láthatjuk egymást. De amint látszik, nem lesz belőle egyhamar. Írjo[n], édesem: lehe[t]-e még reményem, hogy feljönnek Pest[re]? Édes Jolánkám, {külvesben} két kérdést, de mondja kettőre feleletet.

1. Ha magamba[n] vagyok, fölidézem képed, mert is szeretlek én ojan nagyon téged.
2. Mikor hoz már veled össze egy boldog szép óra? Mikor forr az ajkunk össze üdvösséges csókba?

Jó mulatást kívánok, vasárnap soráit várom. Maradok szerető kedvese, Feri.

Under the stamp: [Iste]n vele, [éd]esem. Ma[ra]dok sze[re]tő ked[v]ese, Feri. Csókolom számtala[n]szor. X

**English**

My beloved sweet Jolánka! I wish that my lines find you in the best of health. As for me, I am just getting by. This week I was at Sándor's and heard this about it: that [rows 7 to 8 unread], that they, my sweet, are coming up to Pest after all; so I began to be glad that in the near future we can see each other more often. But as it seems, nothing will come of it soon. Write, my sweet: may I still hope

that they are coming up to Pest? Sweet Jolánka, [külvesben, not understood] two questions, but give me an answer to both.

1. When I am alone, I call up your image, because I love you so very much.
2. When will a happy, lovely hour at last bring me together with you? When will our lips melt together in a blissful kiss?

I wish you a good time; I await your lines on Sunday. I remain your loving sweetheart, Feri.

Under the stamp: [God be] with you, [my sw]eet. I remain your loving sweetheart, Feri. I kiss you countless times. X

**Slovak**

Moja milovaná sladká Jolánka! Želám si, aby Vás moje riadky zastihli v najlepšom zdraví. Čo sa mňa týka, len tak žijem. Tento týždeň som bol u Šándora a počul som o tom toto: že [riadky 7 až 8 neprečítané], že predsa len oni, moja drahá, prídu hore do Pešti; tak som sa začal tešiť, že sa v blízkej budúcnosti budeme vídať častejšie. Ale ako sa zdá, tak skoro z toho nič nebude. Napíšte, drahá: môžem ešte dúfať, že prídu hore do Pešti? Sladká Jolánka, [külvesben, nerozumiem] dve otázky, ale dajte mi odpoveď na obe.

1. Keď som sám, vyvolávam si Váš obraz, lebo Vás tak veľmi ľúbim.
2. Kedy ma už spojí s Vami šťastná, krásna hodina? Kedy sa naše pery spoja v blaženom bozku?

Želám Vám dobrú zábavu, v nedeľu čakám Vaše riadky. Zostávam Váš milujúci milý, Feri.

Pod známkou: [Boh] s Vami, [drah]á. Zostávam Váš milujúci milý, Feri. Bozkávam Vás nespočetnekrát. X

## Reproduction

From the repository root: `python3 -I ciphers/hcp-1286/work/decode_rev2.py`. It checks the SHA-256 of the scans, decodes the sign ledger `work/ledger-rev2.txt` (one token per written sign) and prints the literal rows and the normalized text.

## Uncertainties

- **Rows 7 to 8, unread clause.** Literal `bajosa{|}zeszebbolva[l]a + mi`. The first sign is faint and its bowl unclear, a stroke between a and z has no value, the loop after `szebb` could be o or i, and the l lies under a cancel line. Tried and rejected: `bájos az, és szebb ... valami`, `bajosan`, `ha jó az idő`, `az eszébe`, `olvasni`. No sense is claimed.
- **Row 8** `hogy még ők, édesem` is a proposal: the sign after e is partly covered, and `megy ő kedesem` divides the same signs differently.
- **Row 16** `külvesben`**.** Nine clean signs, not understood. `küldésben`, `különben`, `küldök` and `levélben` do not fit the signs.
- **Restorations by word sense, signs not individually seen:** row 5 `S[á]ndor` (the name agrees with HCP 1216 and 1217), row 6 `hal[lott]am`, row 9 `[r]e hát így`, row 11 `lát[hat]juk`.
- **Under the stamp:** `[Iste]`, `[éd]`, `[ra]` and `[re]` are lost with the torn paper and restored by formula. `ked[v]ese` is probably a spelling omission. A 9-shaped sign before the last e of kedvese is unexplained, and the final X is taken as a kiss mark.
- `feljönnek` is plural and is translated "they", whose identity the card does not state. A loose plural for Jolánka herself cannot be excluded.
- **Numerals 1 and 2:** the two questions are the two `Mikor` lines, both under 2, so the numerals' role is open.
- **Writer's spellings** are normalized: `iletcsak`, `kedesem`, `irjo`, `lehe e`, `jönek`, `magamba`, `ojan`, `ketöre`, `monda`, `talaszor`. Row 16 repeats `-la-` in `Jo|lalánkám`.

## Review summary

An independent reviewer, a separate Claude Opus 5.5 agent, rebuilt the key from HCP 1216, decoded the ledger with its own script and checked most rows on its own crops. Verdict REVISE. It confirmed the key, the identification and most of the reading, and it reported these points, all addressed:

- Rows 7 to 8 had a forced sense. The clause is now given as signs read, and the status dropped from complete to partial.
- The y of `oly` had no place on the card and was removed.
- The ledger for row 8 lacked `gy m e`, now added.
- The poem opens with Ha, not De: "When I am alone", not "But I am alone".
- Row 17 has one t (`ketöre`), and the spelling list was extended.
- The under-stamp brackets were corrected (`számtala[n]szor`) and explained.
- The "two questions" are the two `Mikor` lines, not the two verses.
- Restorations are no longer described as seen.
- The plain address is now recorded.

The solver also corrected "you" to "they" for the plural `feljönnek`. The reviewer did not check rows 10, 12, 13, 15, 21 and 25 sign by sign, and it found no reading for row 7 or `külvesben` either.

## Sources

Portal record https://crypto.hcportal.eu/dashboard/cryptograms/1286 (captured 2026-10-30; files and hashes in SOURCES.md). Key from the finished card HCP 1216 in this repository.